

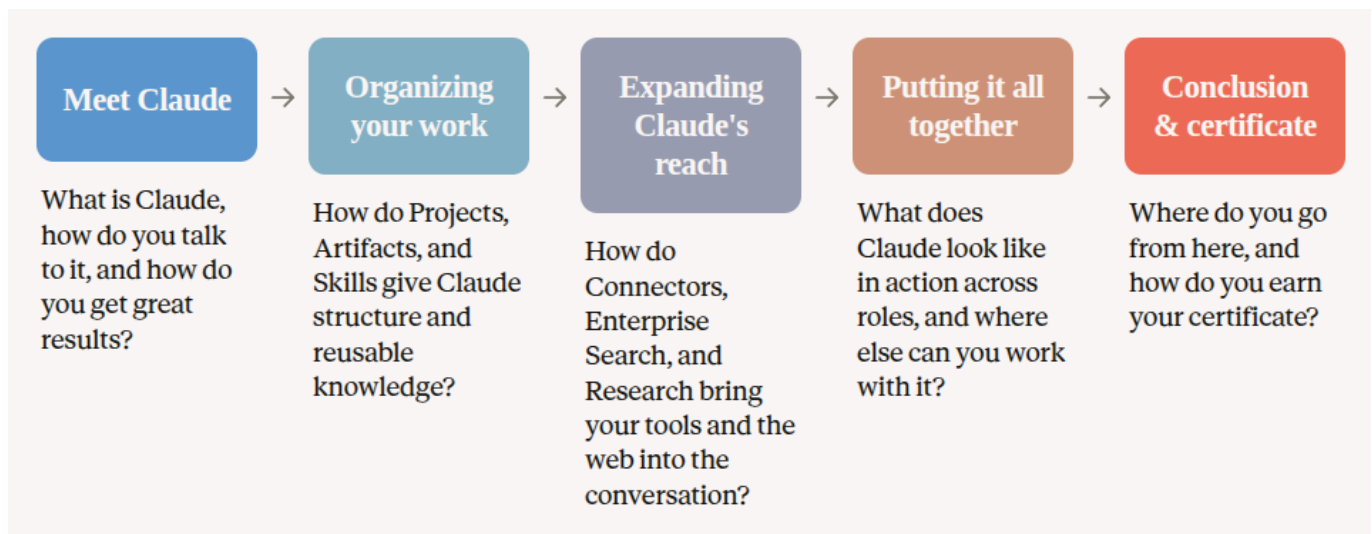
What is Claude?

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson you'll be able to:

- Explain what Claude is and the principles that guide its design
- Describe Claude's core capabilities and how it differs from a simple chatbot
- Identify the different ways to access Claude (web, desktop, and mobile)

Course roadmap



What is Claude?

Claude is more than a chatbot—it's an AI assistant designed to be your thinking partner. In this lesson you'll learn what makes Claude different from other AI tools and see how it can help with a wide variety of work tasks.

Key takeaways

- **Claude is built to be helpful, harmless, and honest:** At a high level, Claude is guided by principles that help it avoid toxic or discriminatory outputs, avoid helping humans engage in illegal or unethical activities, and broadly behave as a helpful, honest, and harmless AI system. This approach, called Constitutional AI, means Claude is trained to align with human values and operate transparently.
- **Claude is more than a chatbot:** Claude is capable of a wide variety of conversational and text processing tasks while maintaining a high degree of reliability and predictability, including summarization, search, creative and collaborative writing, Q&A, coding, and more. Think of Claude as a thought partner who can help you tackle complex problems, and work through challenging situations, not just answer simple questions.
- **Claude is designed to be steerable and collaborative:** Claude can take direction on personality, tone, and behavior, and customers report that Claude is much less likely to produce harmful outputs, easier to converse with, and more steerable—so you can get your desired output with less effort.

- **You can access Claude wherever you work:** Claude apps are available to all plan types—Free, Pro, Max, Team, and Enterprise. Your conversations, projects, memory, and preferences sync across all devices when you're signed in. Whether you're at your desk or on the go, Claude is available through web, desktop, and mobile apps.

Understanding Claude's capabilities

Claude can help with a wide range of tasks that go far beyond simple question-and-answer interactions to assistant-like partnership that can both automate and augment your work. Here's a few things Claude excels at:

- **Writing and content creation:** Claude can collaborate with you on social media posts, professional emails, and complex reports. Because Claude is trained to take direction on personality and tone, you can iterate together on structure and clarity until your voice comes through clearly.
- **Research and analysis:** Claude helps you explore research angles, compile findings, and analyze data to surface meaningful insights. You can upload documents and Claude will help you make sense of complex information—this is enabled by Claude's large context window, which can ingest 200K+ tokens (about 500 pages of text or more), with up to 1M tokens available on Pro, Max, Team, and Enterprise plans when using supported models. This allows Claude to consider extensive materials in a single conversation.
- **Coding assistance:** Coding is one of Claude's greatest strengths. Claude's strong performance on real-world coding tasks means it can help you write, debug, and explain code across multiple programming languages.
- **Problem-solving and reasoning:** Claude handles complex cognitive tasks, mathematical problems, strategic thinking and analysis, and research. Claude's recent Opus and Sonnet models are hybrid models offering two modes: near-instant responses and extended thinking for deeper reasoning. Anthropic Extended thinking allows Claude to work through problems step-by-step, making it well-suited for tasks that require careful analysis.
- **Learning new things:** Whether you're learning a new skill, exploring unfamiliar domains, or working through complex challenges, Claude can adapt to your learning style and pace. Learning mode is a new Claude experience that guides your reasoning process rather than providing answers, helping develop critical thinking skills.

Get inspired on ways to use Claude in your specific function by exploring our [Use-case gallery](#). For a deeper dive into what AI can (and can't) do, see our [AI Capabilities & Limitations](#) course.

Ways to access Claude

Claude is the intelligence—the AI assistant you're learning to work with throughout this course. That same intelligence is available across multiple interfaces, each suited to different types of tasks

- [Claude.ai](#) (and the associated mobile and desktop apps) are the primary way most people interact with Claude. Here, you can ask questions, brainstorm ideas, create and edit documents, and a lot more. Claude.ai is ideal for conversations, writing assistance, research, analysis, and creating files. This is our focus in this course.

- [Claude Code](#) is an agentic coding tool that is designed for developers but can be used for all kinds of file manipulation on your desktop. Claude Code can directly edit files, run commands, and create commits.
- [Claude Tag](#) brings Claude directly into Slack. You can chat with Claude in the AI assistant header from any channel or conversation, or by tagging @Claude in threads. When you connect Slack to Claude, Claude searches your workspace's channels, direct messages, and shared files to find the context you need for better responses and research.
- [Claude Design](#) is a dedicated space for turning ideas into working interfaces. Describe what you want — or start from a sketch or screenshot — and Claude builds an interactive prototype you can refine and hand off to your team.
- [Claude for Microsoft 365](#) brings Claude into Excel, PowerPoint, Word, and Outlook as a sidebar, so you can analyze, draft, and edit inside the document you already have open — and carry context from one app to the next.

This course will focus primarily on Claude.ai, but you can also check out Claude Code in Action for more information on using Claude in development workflows.

Lesson reflection

In the next lesson, you'll learn how to navigate the Claude interface, start your first conversation, and understand the basics of how Claude responds to your messages.

Acknowledgments and license

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